

Team Sports Including Traditional Filipino Games

Introduction: The Power of Playing Together

From basketball courts to barangay streets, Filipinos have long understood that games are more than mere entertainment. They are training grounds for life. Whether through modern team sports or traditional Filipino games known as **Laro ng Lahi**, the act of playing together develops essential interpersonal skills that extend far beyond the game itself.

Social interaction in sports refers to how individuals communicate, cooperate, and build relationships with others through physical activity. In team sports, this happens through coordinated plays, giving and receiving feedback, strategizing together, encouraging teammates, and resolving conflicts that arise during competition. Positive social interaction in sports fosters trust, empathy, respect, and shared goals — qualities that transfer directly to classrooms, families, workplaces, and communities.

This reading material examines the role of team sports and traditional Filipino games in developing social competence, the interpersonal skills that games cultivate, and the **DEAR MAN strategy** — a practical framework for assertive, respectful communication that can be applied both on and off the field.

Part 1: Social Interaction in Sports

Definition

Social interaction in sports refers to the ways individuals communicate, cooperate, and build relationships with others through physical activity and games. It encompasses verbal communication (calling plays, offering encouragement), nonverbal communication (gestures, eye contact, body language), and the emotional dynamics of teamwork (sharing success, coping with loss, resolving disagreements).

Why Team Sports Are Powerful Tools for Social Competence

Skill	How Sports Develop It
Communication	Players must coordinate plays, share information, and call out strategies in real time
Collaboration	Winning requires working together toward a shared goal; individual talent alone is insufficient
Responsibility	Each member's performance affects the entire team's outcome
Fair play and respect	Sports teach accepting outcomes gracefully, showing sportsmanship regardless of result
Resilience	Losing teaches how to recover, learn, and try again
Conflict resolution	Disagreements about strategy, playing time, or calls must be addressed constructively

Part 2: Team Sports and Traditional Filipino Games

Modern Team Sports and Their Social Benefits

Team Sport	Social Skills Developed	How It Promotes Interaction
Volleyball	Communication, trust, rotation-based cooperation	Players must talk constantly, rotate positions, and support each other during plays
Basketball	Strategic thinking, leadership, quick collaboration	Requires rapid team decisions, assists, and role delegation

Team Sport	Social Skills Developed	How It Promotes Interaction
Football (Soccer)	Group dynamics, resilience, goal-setting	Diverse positions require synchronized movement and mutual support

Traditional Filipino Games (Laro ng Lahi)

Traditional Game	Social Skills Developed	How It Promotes Interaction
Patintero	Spatial awareness, turn-taking, verbal cues	Enhances peer bonding and physical coordination through chasing and blocking roles
Tumbang Preso	Inclusivity, cooperation, friendly competition	Builds community, especially in informal neighborhood settings
Luksong Baka	Trust, timing, mutual encouragement	Requires players to coordinate jumps and support those who hesitate
Sipa	Focus, precision, turn-taking	Develops patience and respect for others' turns

Why Laro ng Lahi Matters

Traditional Filipino games are culturally significant because they:

- Require minimal equipment, making them accessible to all
- Are often played in informal, mixed-age groups, building community across generations
- Emphasize cooperation and enjoyment over intense competition
- Preserve cultural heritage and Filipino identity
- Develop physical skills alongside social and emotional intelligence

Part 3: Mindfulness in Traditional Games

Playing traditional games mindfully — paying attention on purpose, in the present moment, without judgment — transforms physical activity into a practice of self-awareness and emotional regulation.

Mindful Patintero

Traditional Patintero setup: A grid with 3–4 vertical lanes and 1–2 horizontal lines. Taggers position themselves on lines; runners attempt to cross the entire grid and return without being tagged.

Mindful modifications:

- Begin with a grounding exercise: *"Feel your feet on the ground. Notice your breath. Inhale slowly. Exhale completely."*
- Set a mindful intention: *"I will move with focus and awareness."*
- Runners move deliberately and silently, paying attention to foot placement and body balance
- Taggers practice focused gaze and controlled movements — no shouting or sudden lunges
- Introduce a breath cue: one deep breath before each run to stay calm and present

Reflection questions during play:

- *"How am I feeling right now?"*
- *"What do I notice about my body?"*
- *"How can I be fully present in this moment?"*

Mindful Luksong Baka

Traditional Luksong Baka setup: One player (the "Baka") crouches in the middle. Others take turns jumping over without touching them. After each full round, the Baka raises their position slightly (kneeling → squatting → bending forward).

Mindful modifications:

- Begin with a body scan: close eyes and notice tension from head to toe
 - Before jumping, each player pauses, takes one deep breath, and mentally says, *"I am present."*
 - Players jump quietly and intentionally — no running starts or rushing
 - If a player hesitates or feels nervous, they notice it without judgment: *"What am I feeling right now?"*
 - Reinforce non-judgmental peer support: no teasing, only encouragement
 - Celebrate effort, not just success
-

Part 4: The DEAR MAN Strategy for Assertive Communication

In sports and teamwork, communication is essential. However, expressing needs clearly and respectfully — especially during conflict — can be challenging. The **DEAR MAN strategy** provides a structured framework for assertive, goal-oriented communication.

The Seven Components of DEAR MAN

Letter	Component	Definition	Sports Example
D	Describe	Clearly explain the situation using facts, not judgments	<i>"In our last game, we struggled to cover the left side of the court."</i>
E	Express	Share feelings honestly and respectfully using "I" statements	<i>"I felt frustrated when I did not get a chance to play in the second half."</i>
A	Assert	State needs or desires clearly and directly	<i>"I would like more opportunities to play in the second half."</i>

Letter	Component	Definition	Sports Example
R	Reinforce	Explain the positive outcomes of meeting the request	<i>"If I get some playing time, I will be more motivated and can help the team with fresh energy."</i>
M	Mindful	Stay focused on the issue; avoid getting distracted or escalating	<i>"Let's focus on this game right now and not argue about past plays."</i>
A	Appear confident	Maintain confident posture, tone, and eye contact	<i>"I am confident that if we focus on rotating positions, we will have a better chance."</i>
N	Negotiate	Be willing to compromise and find middle ground	<i>"How about we rotate positions every other game so everyone gets a fair chance?"</i>

Why DEAR MAN Works in Team Settings

Benefit	Explanation
Prevents resentment	Expressing issues early prevents accumulation of frustration
Maintains relationships	Respectful communication preserves trust even during disagreement
Increases likelihood of success	Clear, reinforced requests are more likely to be granted
Reduces defensiveness	Describing facts rather than attacking people keeps listeners open
Builds team cohesion	Regular use of DEAR MAN normalizes constructive conflict resolution

Sample DEAR MAN Application in a Team Conflict

Scenario: A basketball player feels they are not receiving enough passes during games, even when they are open.

DEAR MAN response:

- **Describe:** *"In the last two games, I have noticed that when I am open on the wing, the ball has not come to me."*
 - **Express:** *"I feel frustrated because I want to contribute more to the team's scoring."*
 - **Assert:** *"I would like the team to look for me more when I am open."*
 - **Reinforce:** *"If I get more touches, I can draw defenders away from others and create more scoring opportunities for everyone."*
 - **Mindful:** *"Let us focus on improving our ball movement rather than blaming anyone for past games."*
 - **Appear confident:** Maintain steady eye contact and calm tone.
 - **Negotiate:** *"Could we practice some plays designed to get everyone involved, including perimeter shots?"*
-

Part 5: The Qualities of a Strong Team Player

Beyond physical skill, effective team players demonstrate specific attitudes and behaviors.

Quality	Description
Communication	Calls out plays, offers encouragement, provides constructive feedback
Reliability	Shows up on time, fulfills assigned role, puts in effort consistently
Respect	Treats teammates, opponents, coaches, and officials with courtesy
Selflessness	Prioritizes team success over personal statistics or recognition
Resilience	Recovers quickly from mistakes; does not dwell on errors

Quality	Description
Coachability	Accepts feedback openly; willing to adjust and improve
Encouragement	Supports teammates after errors; celebrates others' successes
Fair play	Follows rules; accepts officials' decisions gracefully; does not cheat to win

Part 6: Applying Teamwork Skills Beyond Sports

The skills developed through team sports and traditional Filipino games transfer directly to other life domains.

Skill	Application in School	Application in Career	Application in Community
Communication	Group projects, class discussions	Team meetings, client interactions	Barangay assemblies, volunteer coordination
Collaboration	Shared assignments, study groups	Cross-departmental projects	Community clean-ups, disaster response
Conflict resolution	Disagreements with classmates	Workplace disputes	Neighborhood mediation
Fair play and respect	Following school rules	Professional ethics	Civic responsibility
Resilience	Recovering from low grades	Bouncing back from setbacks	Coping with community challenges

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Social Interaction in Sports	How individuals communicate, cooperate, and build relationships through physical activity and games
Laro ng Lahi	Traditional Filipino games that preserve cultural heritage and emphasize cooperation
Mindfulness	Paying attention on purpose, in the present moment, without judgment
DEAR MAN	A seven-step strategy for assertive, respectful communication: Describe, Express, Assert, Reinforce, Mindful, Appear confident, Negotiate
Sportsmanship	Fair, respectful, and gracious behavior toward opponents, officials, and teammates
Social Competence	The ability to interact effectively and appropriately with others in various social contexts

Review Questions

Responses should be written on a separate sheet of paper.

1. What is **social interaction in sports**? Why are team sports considered powerful tools for developing social competence?
2. Name three traditional Filipino games (Laro ng Lahi). For each, identify one social skill it develops and explain how.
3. A volleyball player feels they are not being set up for attacks even when they are in good position. Using the DEAR MAN strategy, write a script of what they could say to their teammate.
4. What does it mean to play a traditional game **mindfully**? Describe two mindfulness practices that could be applied to Patintero.
5. A student argues, "*Team sports only improve physical skills, not social ones.*" How would you respond based on what you have learned in this article?